

○ **Modifiers:**

A modifier is a word or group of words that make the meaning of another word more definite. It can be an adjective, an adverb, or a predicate adjective.

1. An **adjective** is used to add meaning to a noun. For example, Train whistles *have a mournful sound*.
2. An **adverb** is used to add meaning to a verb. For example, The train whistles *mournfully*.
3. A **predicate adjective** qualifies a subject. Whether to use the adjective form or the adverb form as a predicate adjective depends on what it is adding meaning to, a noun or a verb, and the kind of verb used. Look at these two examples,
 - a) The book *looked interesting*. (*Looked* is used as a linking verb here and the word the meaning is added to is the *book* [noun], hence the adjective *interesting* is used.)
 - b) The child *looked excitedly* at the new book. (In this sentence *looked* is used as an action verb and therefore, an adverb *excitedly* is used as the predicate adjective to modify the subject.)
4. If modifiers are not placed appropriately in a sentence, confusion might occur.

○ **Modifier Errors:**

Misplaced Modifiers:

Modifiers are placed with the words they are modifying and if they are placed in the wrong place, the meaning of the sentence can change. A misplaced modifier seems to modify the wrong word which can lead to confusion. Look at the following sentence:

- **My sister walked in as I was scrubbing the floor with her new baby.**

The modifying phrase “with her new baby” should logically modify how the sister walked. The sister walked into the room together with her new baby. However, the modifier is closest to the verb “scrubbing.” What this sentence actually suggests is that I was using the baby to scrub the floor!

Corrected: My sister walked in with her new baby as I was scrubbing the floor.

Dangling Modifiers:

Modifying phrases must have a word to modify and should not dangle in the sentence alone. A dangling modifier seems to modify the wrong word or no word at all because the word it should modify has been omitted from the sentence. For example,

- **The experiment was a failure, not having studied the lab instructions carefully.**

The person or persons who failed to study the instructions is missing from the sentence.

Corrected: The class failed to study the lab instructions carefully and failed the experiment.

Note: Sometimes in a sentence, a modifier can logically modify more than one word. Be careful to specify which word is being modified.

Example: The family *nearly* lost everything in the tornado.

The family lost *nearly* everything in the tornado.

In the first example, the placement of “nearly” makes it an adverb, modifying “lost.” This sentence suggests that the family almost suffered loss but did not. In the second example, “nearly” is an adjective modifying “everything.” This sentence suggests that the family lost a great deal – almost everything.